What Makes It Mine?

aka Art & Authorship

Session 3a: Originality & Lineage



Philosophy of Art with Rebecca Millsop, Ph.D.

ARTIST COMMONS

How This Works

- Not a traditional philosophy class
- No argument analysis, no debating which theory is correct

The Goal:

1. Know the major theories – understand what they claim
2. Use them as tools – apply them to your own practice

Format:

- Talk + Reflection Questions + Q&A at the end
- Drop questions in the chat as we go
- Post follow ups in the community app - I'll engage there!

The Four Questions

Q1: What am I making?

"I make stuff but is it art?" →
"Here's what makes my work art and why."

Philosophical territory:
ontology and definition

Q2: How does it mean?

“I hope people understand it…” →
"Here's how my art creates meaning."

Philosophical territory:
semiotics and communication

Q3: What makes it mine?

“Everything has already been done!” →
"Here is my lineage & my contribution."

Philosophical territory:
originality and authorship

Q4: Why does it matter?

“Is my work saying anything important?” →
"Here is why my work matters."

Philosophical territory:
value and function

Two Approaches to the Philosophical Problem

Originality & Lineage

If every work comes from *somewhere*, what makes it original?

Authorship & Circulation

If meaning & materials move beyond me, what makes me the author?

Originality & Lineage

From: “Everything has already been done.”
To: “I can name what I inherit and what I do with it.”

Today’s Focus: **Four Frameworks**

1. Genius and Exemplary Originality ✨
2. Tradition and the Historical Sense 🧬
3. Anxiety of Influence ↩️
4. Originality and Repetition 🔁

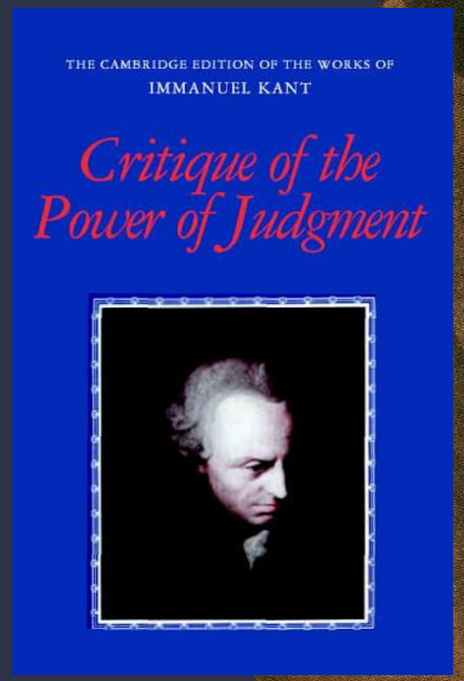
Framework 1 ✨

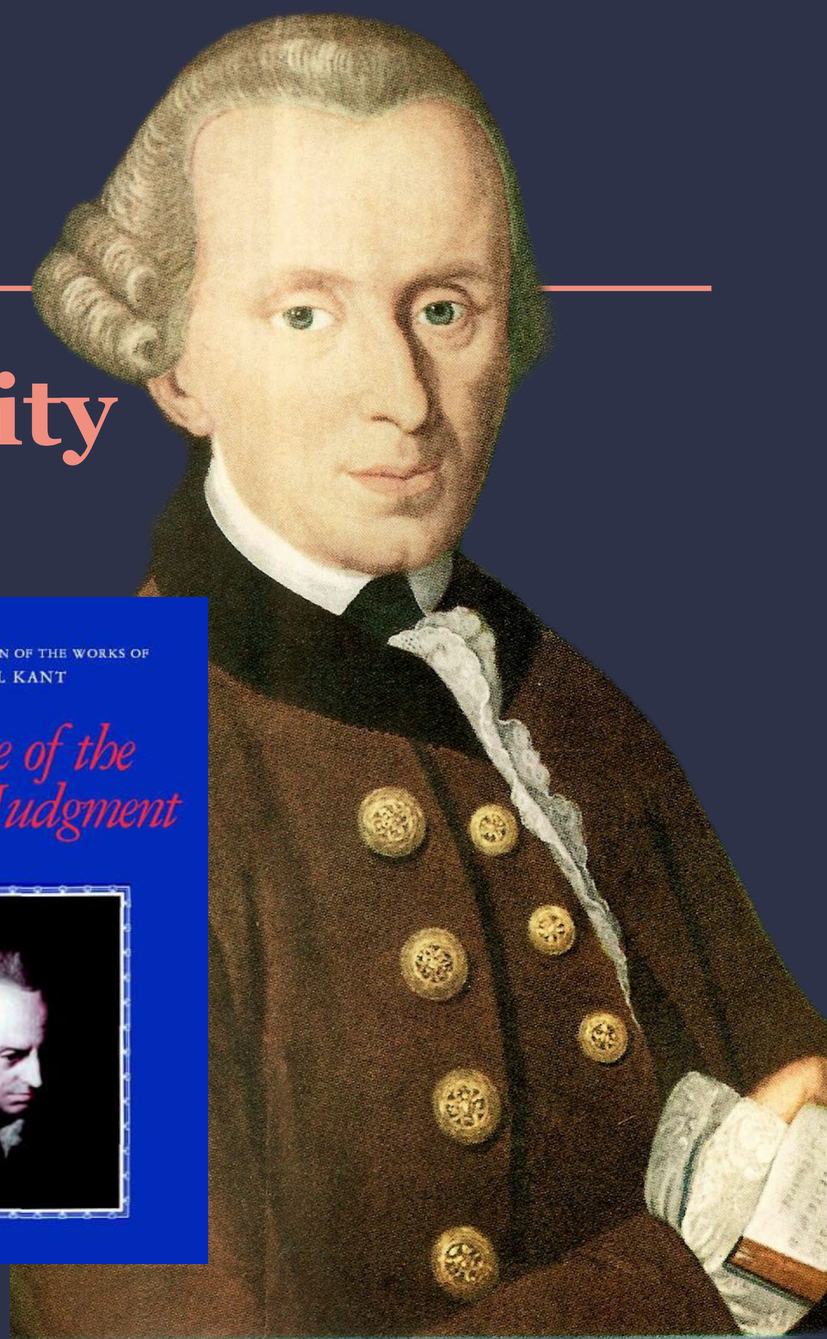
Genius and Exemplary Originality

Kant: Genius is the talent that gives the rule to art.

Original: No existing rule could have fully prescribed the work in advance.

Exemplary: The work becomes a model for other artists to learn from.

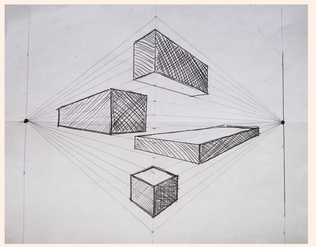


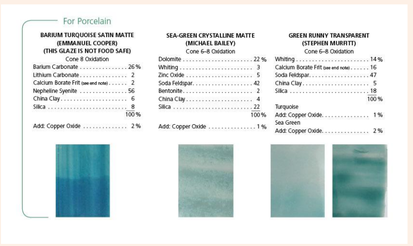


How Genius Changes the Sequence

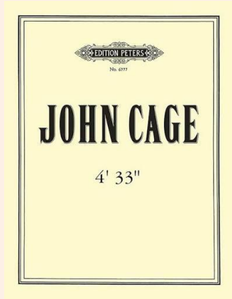
Rule-First Model

Rule → **Artwork**









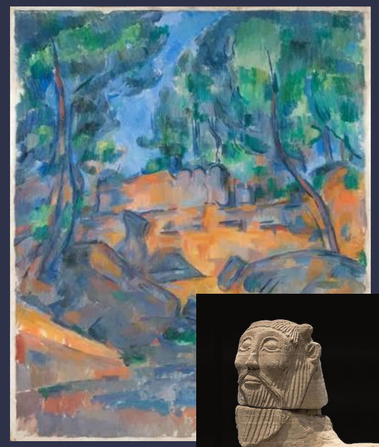
Kant's Genius Model

Artwork → **New Possibility for Art**





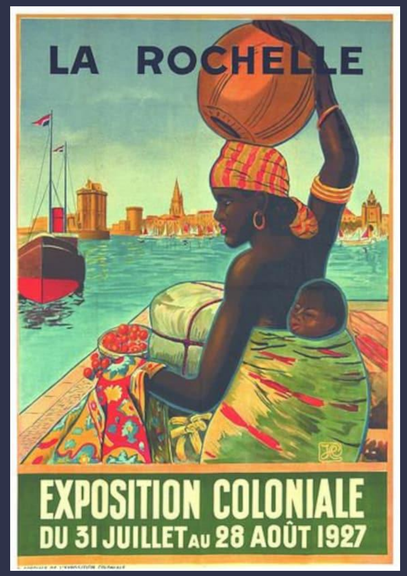
Where It Gets Complicated

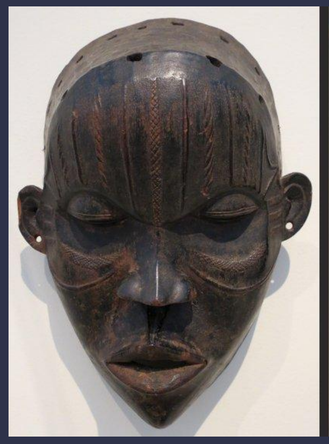






Pablo Picasso, *Les Demoiselles d'Avignon,* 1907.



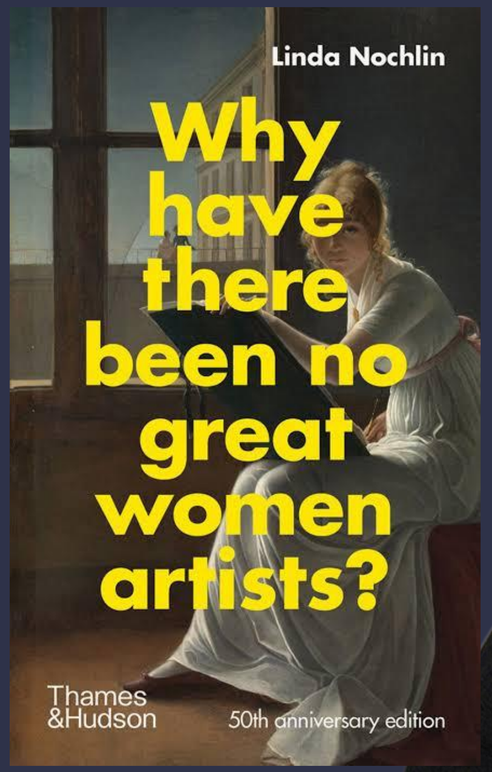






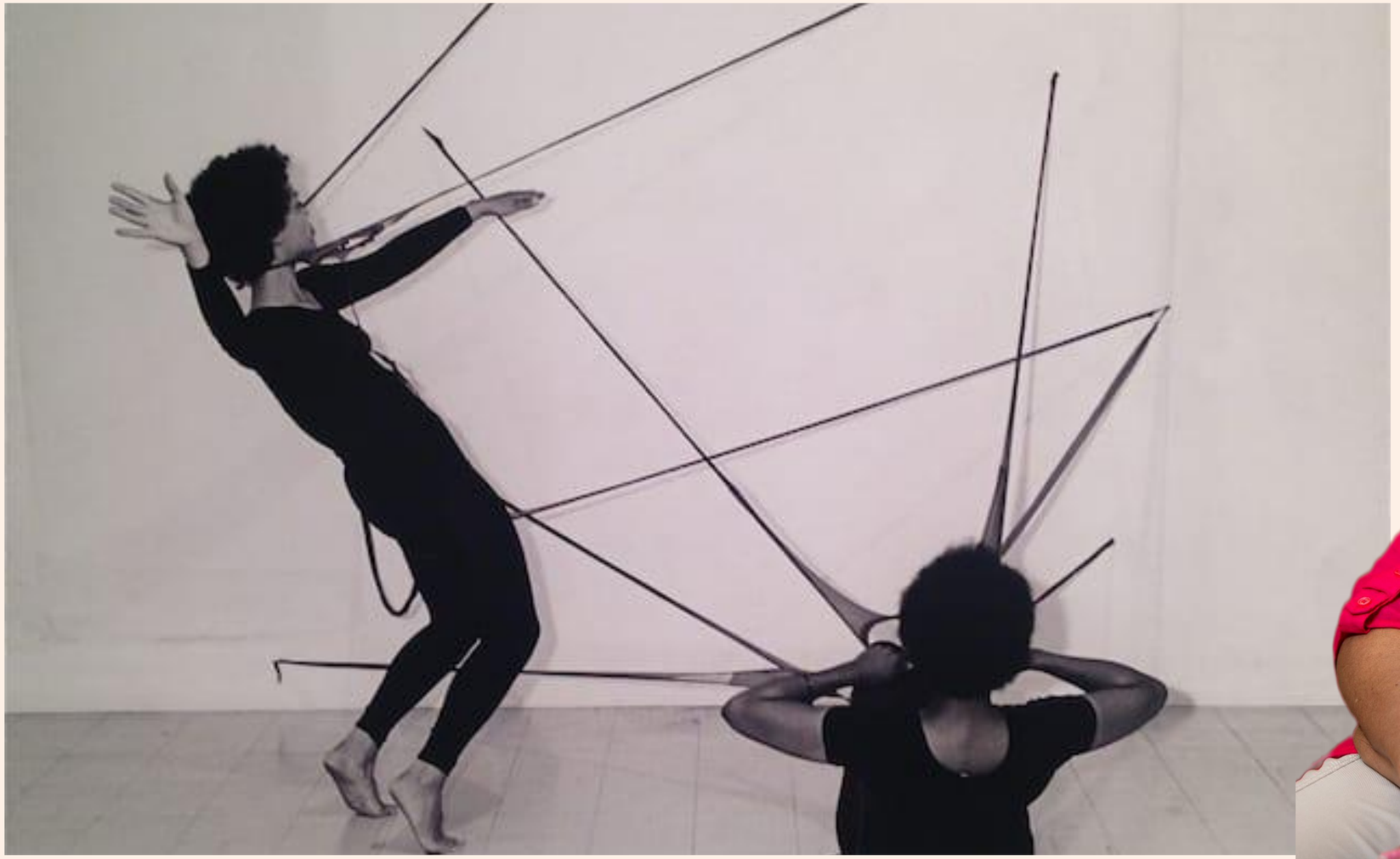
Renegotiating Genius

She asks:
What had to be available for someone to develop a serious practice and have that practice recognized?





Senga Nengudi



R.S.V.P. 1977. Sculptures activated by Senga Nengudi and Maren Hassinger, Pearl C. Wood Gallery, Los Angeles.



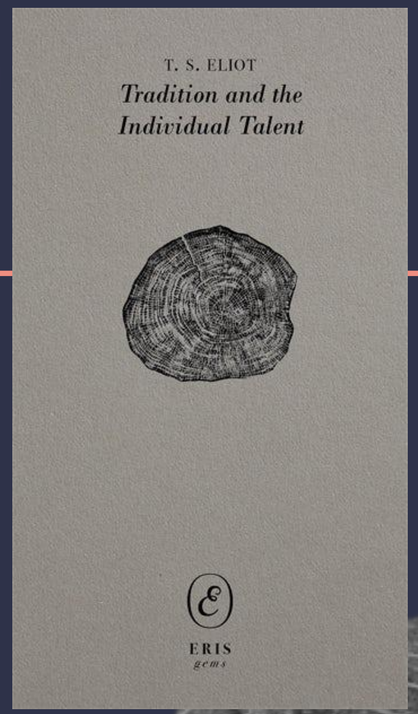
For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose a recent work:

What does this work make possible?

Framework 2



Tradition and the Historical Sense

Tradition is an *active* order.

Historical sense is the artist's awareness that the past is past, while allowing the past to engage the present work.



From Genius to Individual Talent

Kant

Originality begins in a special capacity of the artist

Genius - Special Capacity of the Artist

↓

Exemplary Work
Gives rule to art

Eliot

Originality appears in the work's* transformation *of inheritance

Inherited
Language, Form, & Experience

↓

Individual Talent *as Transformation*

↓

New Arrangement *of Inherited Material*

How the Sequence Changes

“Common Sense” Model of Tradition

Lineage, artists, histories, movements → **Artwork**

Eliot’s Model of Tradition

Lineage, artists, histories, movements ↔ **Artwork**



Faith Ringgold. *Woman on a Bridge #1 of 5: Tar Beach.* 1988. Acrylic paint, canvas, printed fabric, ink and thread.

Where It Gets Complicated

Tradition is not neutral.

The artist may have to **recover** or **construct** the relation.

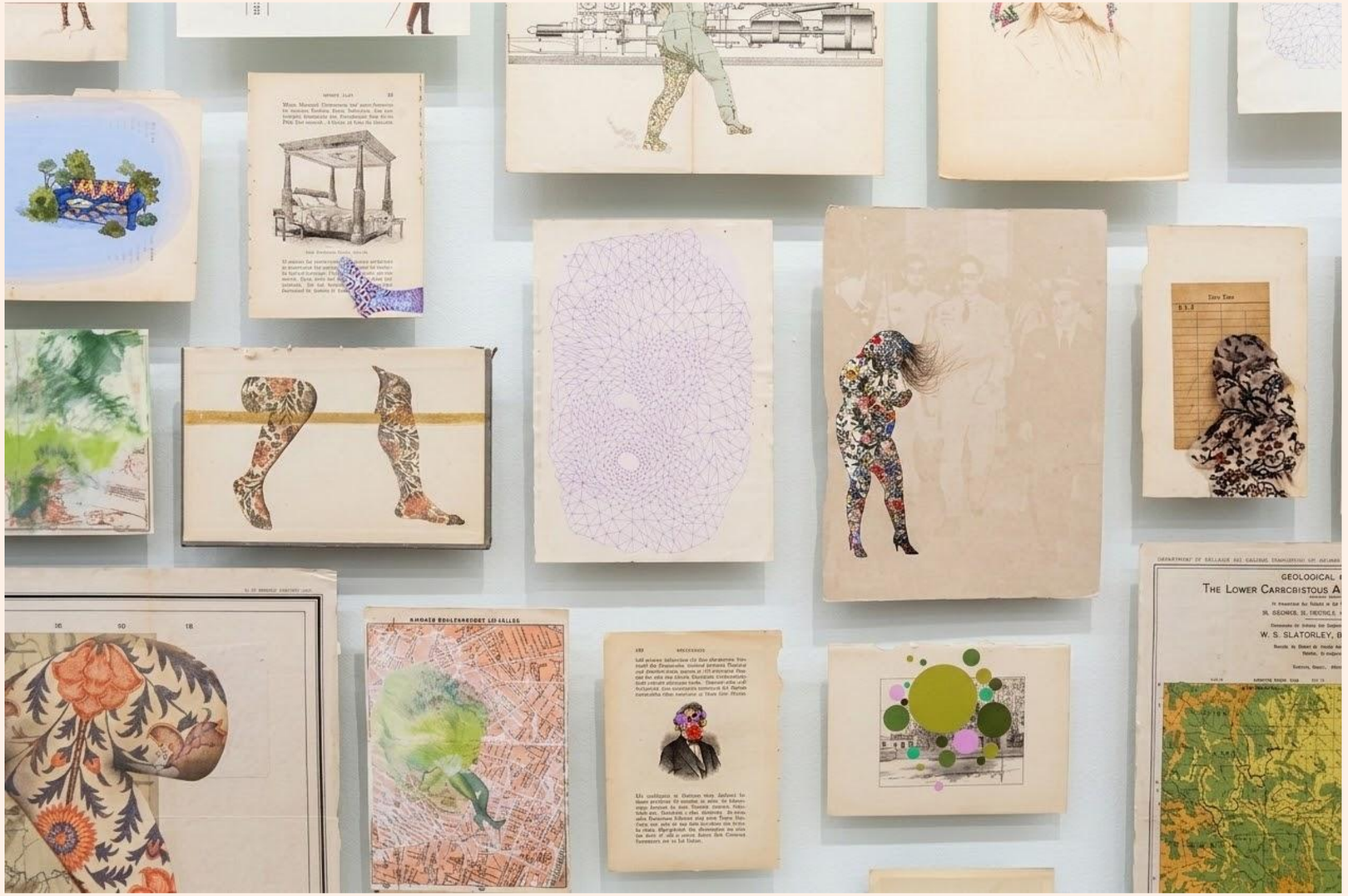
Firelei Báez



Man Without a Country (aka anthropophagist wading in the Artibonite River), 2014-2015. 225 pages from late 19th-century histories of Hispaniola.



Firelei Báez



Man Without a Country (aka anthropophagist wading in the Artibonite River), 2014-2015. 225 pages from late 19th-century histories of Hispaniola.

For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one thing your work inherits.

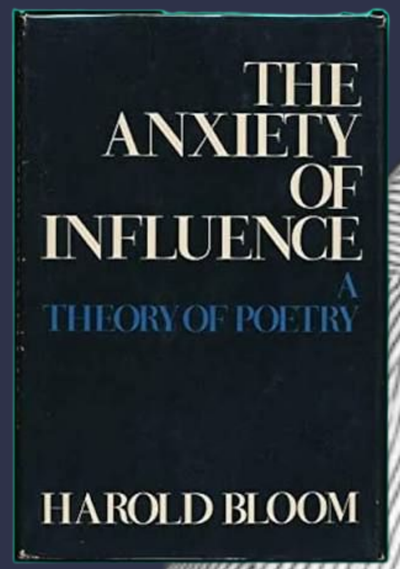
What changes when it enters your work?

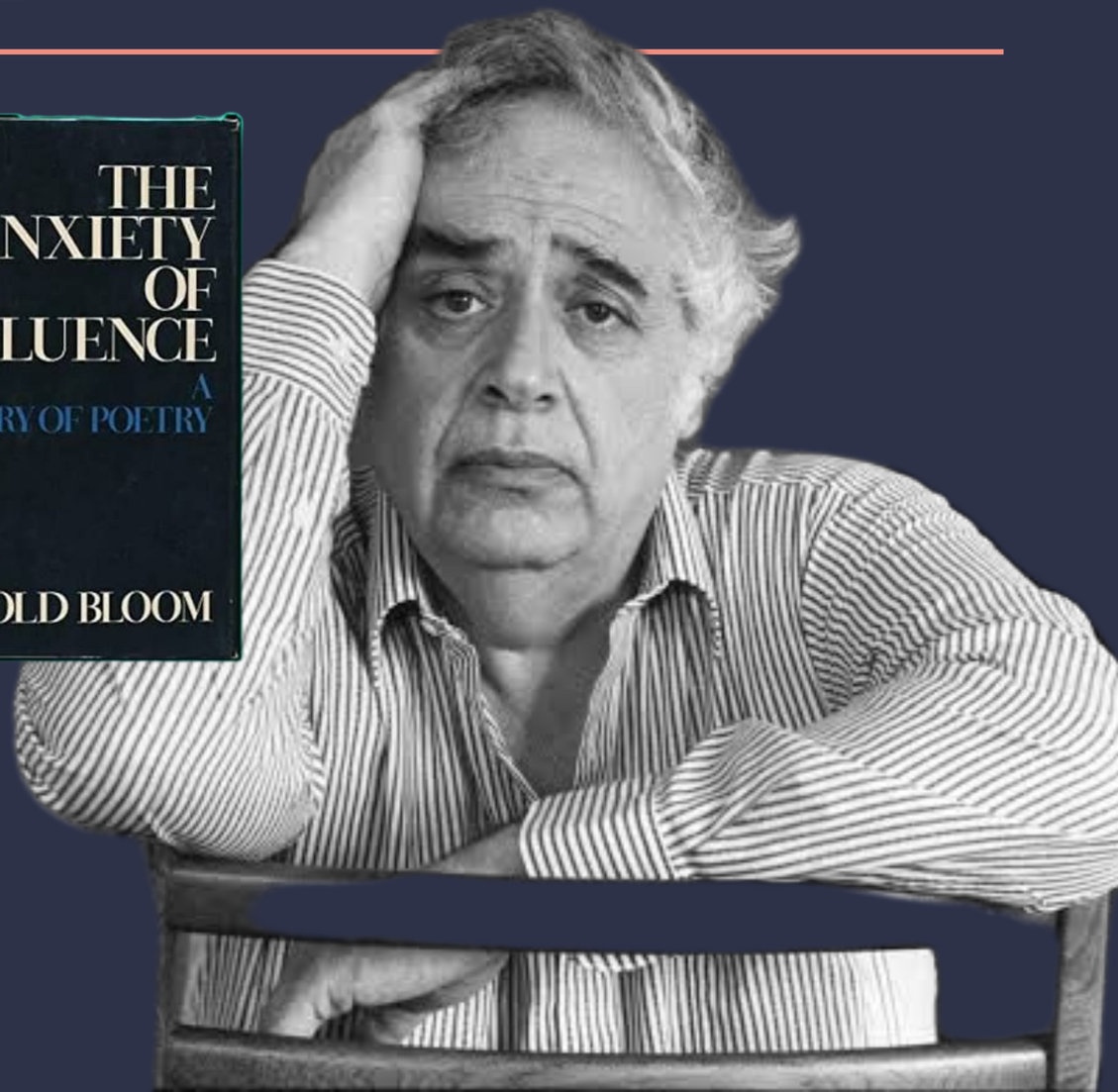
Framework 3 ↩️

Anxiety of Influence

Powerful earlier artists, precursors, shape what later artists can imagine.

New work begins with a creative misreading of that inheritance.





The Path of Influence

Precursor

Pressure

Creative Misreading
Clinamen / The Swerve

Changed Formal Decision



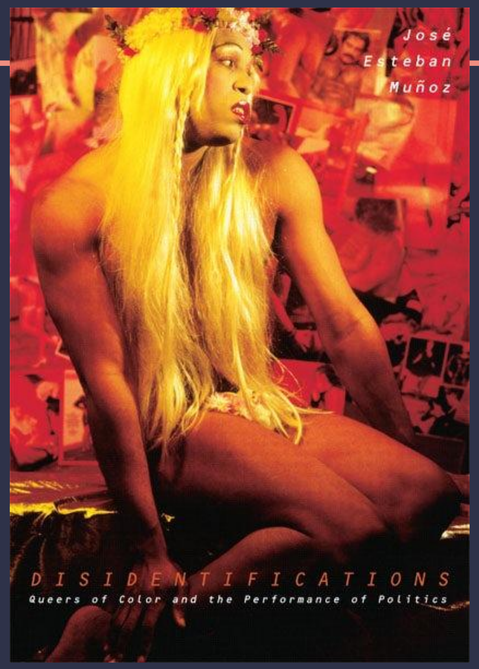
Diego Velazquez, *Portrait of Pope Innocent X*, C. 1650.



Francis Bacon, *Study after Velazquez's Portrait of Pope Innocent X*, C. 1953.

Where It Gets Complicated

Influence becomes a **struggle** for priority between *strong* (masculine) artists…



Disidentification:

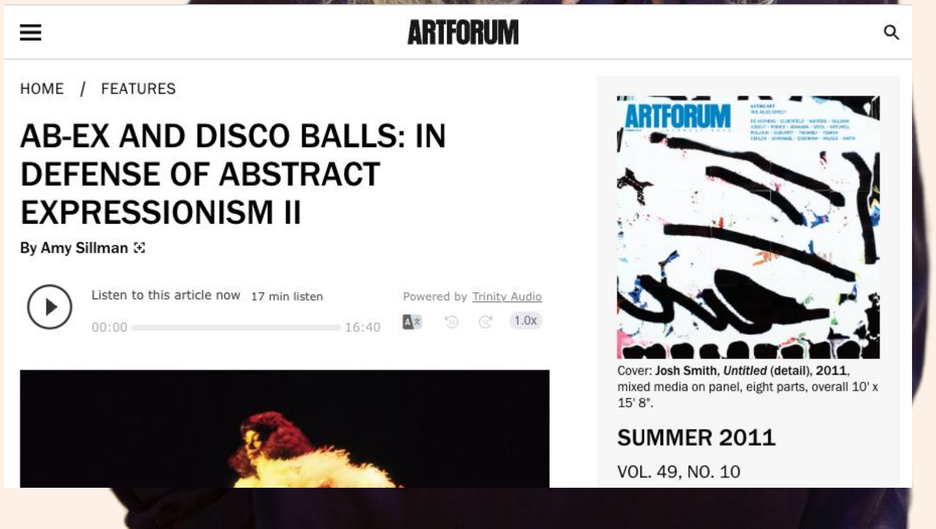
Working on and against an inherited form.



José Esteban Muñoz

Amy Sillman





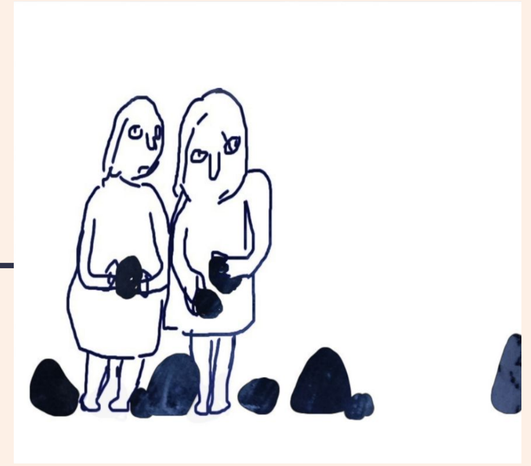


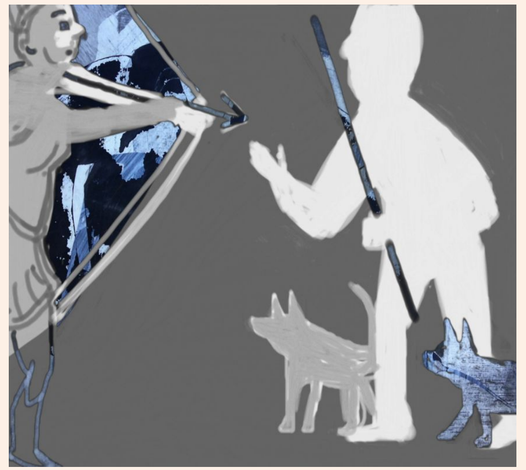
Ghost, 2023-2024.

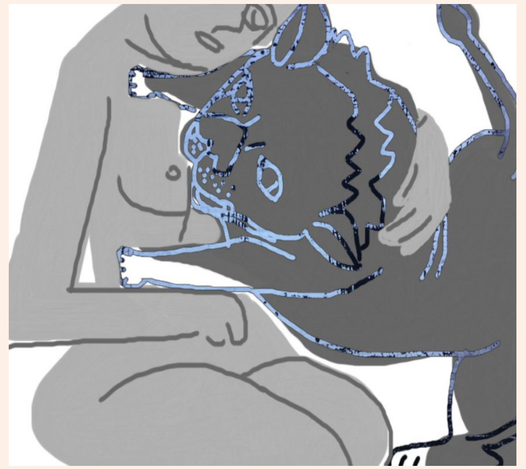
Amy Sillman



After Metamorphoses, 2015-2016.







For your practice…

Takeaway Question

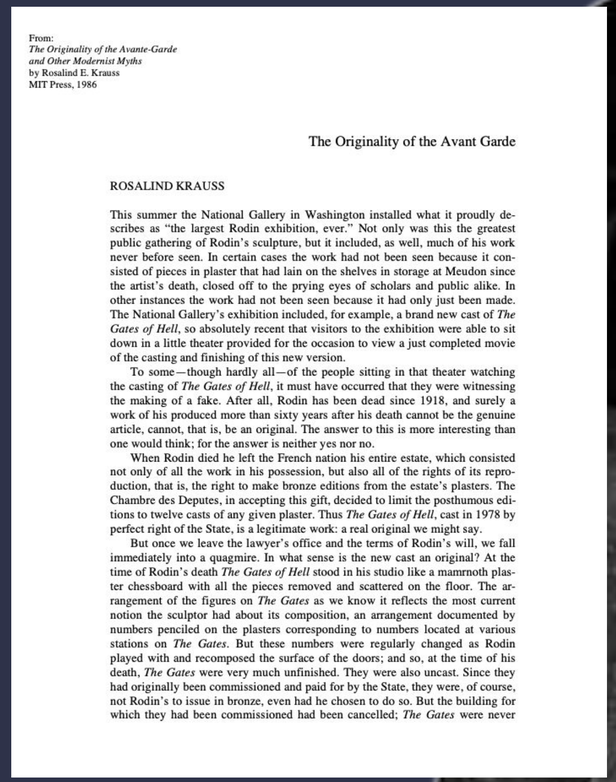
Choose one influence that is active in a work that you are currently making.

Where does your work depart from that influence? How does it depart?

Framework 4 🔁

Originality and Repetition

Claims of a fresh beginning are often built from forms and systems that can be repeated.



From:
The Originality of the Avante-Garde and Other Modernist Myths
by Rosalind E. Krauss
MIT Press, 1986

The Originality of the Avant Garde

ROSALIND KRAUSS

This summer the National Gallery in Washington installed what it proudly describes as "the largest Rodin exhibition, ever." Not only was this the greatest public gathering of Rodin's sculpture, but it included, as well, much of his work never before seen. In certain cases the work had not been seen because it consisted of pieces in plaster that had lain on the shelves in storage at Meudon since the artist's death, closed off to the prying eyes of scholars and public alike. In other instances the work had not been seen because it had only just been made. The National Gallery's exhibition included, for example, a brand new cast of *The Gates of Hell*, so absolutely recent that visitors to the exhibition were able to sit down in a little theater provided for the occasion to view a just completed movie of the casting and finishing of this new version.

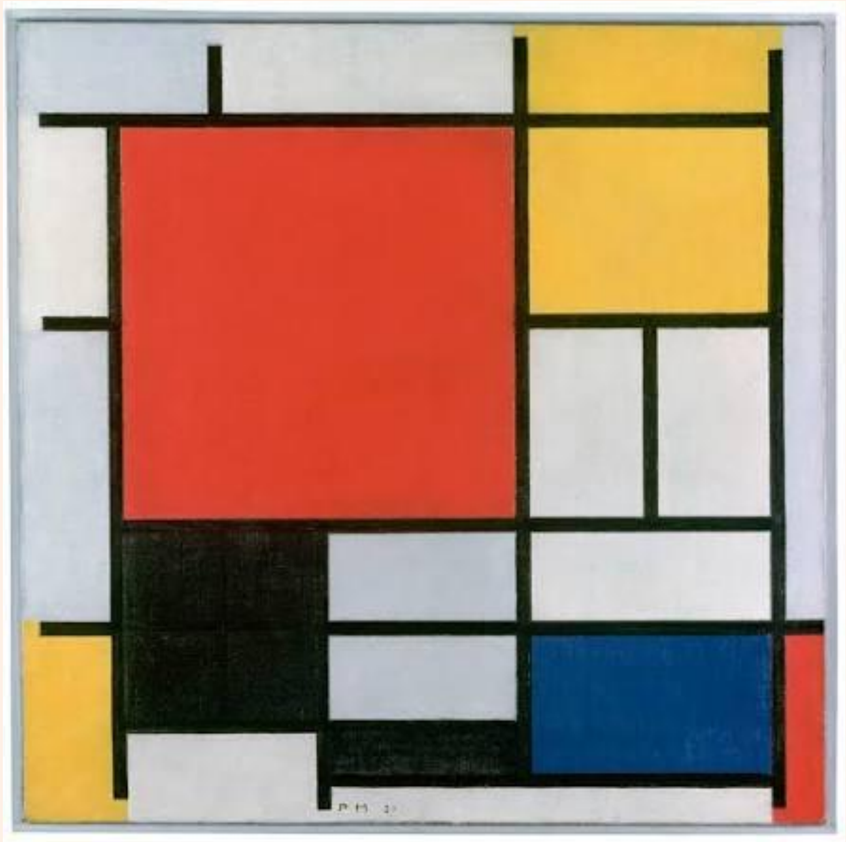
To some—though hardly all—of the people sitting in that theater watching the casting of *The Gates of Hell*, it must have occurred that they were witnessing the making of a fake. After all, Rodin has been dead since 1918, and surely a work of his produced more than sixty years after his death cannot be the genuine article, cannot, that is, be an original. The answer to this is more interesting than one would think; for the answer is neither yes nor no.

When Rodin died he left the French nation his entire estate, which consisted not only of all the work in his possession, but also all of the rights of its reproduction, that is, the right to make bronze editions from the estate's plasters. The Chambre des Deputes, in accepting this gift, decided to limit the posthumous editions to twelve casts of any given plaster. Thus *The Gates of Hell*, cast in 1978 by perfect right of the State, is a legitimate work: a real original we might say.

But once we leave the lawyer's office and the terms of Rodin's will, we fall immediately into a quagmire. In what sense is the new cast an original? At the time of Rodin's death *The Gates of Hell* stood in his studio like a mamrnoth plaster chessboard with all the pieces removed and scattered on the floor. The arrangement of the figures on *The Gates* as we know it reflects the most current notion the sculptor had about its composition, an arrangement documented by numbers penciled on the plasters corresponding to numbers located at various stations on *The Gates*. But these numbers were regularly changed as Rodin played with and recomposed the surface of the doors; and so, at the time of his death, *The Gates* were very much unfinished. They were also uncast. Since they had originally been commissioned and paid for by the State, they were, of course, not Rodin's to issue in bronze, even had he chosen to do so. But the building for which they had been commissioned had been cancelled; *The Gates* were never

Where Is the Original?

The Grid
A repeatable form



Piet Mondrian. *Composition with Large Red Plane, Yellow, Black, Grey and Blue*. 1921.

The Cast
A posthumous original



Auguste Rodin. *The Gates of Hell*.

Where It Gets Complicated

Repetition does not cancel originality.

But… repetition alone does not explain the artist’s contribution.

What did the artist do with what was already there?

Sturtevant



Andy Warhol. *Flowers*. 1964.



Elaine Sturtevant. *Warhol Flowers*. 1969-70



For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one form, image, or process you repeat.

What does repeating it let you do*?*

Four Frameworks

1. Genius and Exemplary Originality ✨
2. Tradition and the Historical Sense 🧬
3. Anxiety of Influence ↩️
4. Originality and Repetition 🔁

One Work, Four Questions

Kant - What possibility does it open?
Eliot - Which earlier work belongs beside it?
Bloom - Where does it take a different turn?
Krauss - What does repeating something let you do?

Up next...

Questions?
Thoughts?
All welcome!

Thank You So Much!

Philosophy of Art with Rebecca Millsop, Ph.D.

ARTIST COMMONS